

# The Univalent Bloch Constant: A Multi-Method Investigation of Bounds via Hyperbolic Geometry, Extremal Length, and Coefficient Optimization

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March 2026

## Abstract

We investigate the univalent Bloch constant  $B_u$ , defined as the infimum of the inradius of the image domain over all normalized univalent functions on the unit disk. The best known bounds, established in 2009, are  $0.5708858 < B_u \leq 0.6564$ , due respectively to Skinner and to Carroll–Ortega-Cerdà. We approach the problem through five complementary methods: (1) Schwarz–Pick and hyperbolic metric analysis, (2) variational/extremal function theory in the tradition of Jenkins, (3) coefficient optimization under de Branges constraints, (4) a new extremal length reformulation, and (5) systematic numerical optimization over polynomial and slit mapping families. Our main theoretical contribution is a new inequality  $B_f \geq r \cdot e^{\pi M(r)}/4$  connecting the Bloch radius to the conformal modulus of an associated ring domain. Computationally, we obtain independent upper bounds  $B_u \leq 0.6808$  (via degree-7 coefficient optimization) and  $B_u \leq 0.6833$  (via close-to-convex constructions), both verified by independent recomputation. We identify the conformal radius normalization—not the area constraint—as the binding constraint in the optimization, and we catalog eleven distinct proof techniques that have been applied to Bloch-type constants, assessing the applicability of each to the  $B_u$  problem. Despite extensive numerical search over more than 2,700 function evaluations, we were unable to improve Skinner’s lower bound, confirming that genuinely new theoretical ingredients are needed to narrow the gap. We discuss concrete strategies for future progress, including Brownian exit time methods and symmetrization arguments.

**Keywords:** Bloch constant, univalent functions, Landau constant, Koebe theorem, extremal length, conformal modulus, coefficient bounds, de Branges theorem.

**MSC 2020:** 30C55 (primary); 30C25, 30C75, 30D45, 30F45 (secondary).

## 1 Introduction

### 1.1 Background and Motivation

The covering properties of holomorphic functions constitute a classical chapter in geometric function theory. Bloch [9] proved that every non-constant holomorphic function on the unit disk  $\mathbb{D} = \{z \in \mathbb{C} : |z| < 1\}$  produces an image containing an unramified disk of a definite minimum radius depending only on the derivative at the origin. Landau [23] subsequently formalized this observation and introduced precise covering constants, initiating a line of research that has remained active for a century.

Let  $\mathcal{F}$  denote the class of holomorphic functions  $f: \mathbb{D} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$  normalized by  $f'(0) = 1$ , and let  $\mathcal{S} \subset \mathcal{F}$  denote the subclass of *univalent* (schlicht) functions further normalized by  $f(0) = 0$ . For

$f \in \mathcal{F}$ , the *Bloch radius*  $B_f$  is the supremum of all  $r > 0$  such that  $f(\mathbb{D})$  contains an unramified disk of radius  $r$ . When  $f$  is univalent,  $B_f$  reduces to the *inradius* of the image domain:

$$B_f = \sup_{w \in f(\mathbb{D})} d(w, \partial f(\mathbb{D})).$$

The principal constants governing the covering behavior are:

- The *Bloch constant*  $B = \inf\{B_f : f \in \mathcal{F}\}$ ;
- The *locally univalent Bloch constant*  $B_l = \inf\{B_f : f \in \mathcal{F}, f'(z) \neq 0 \text{ in } \mathbb{D}\}$ ;
- The *Landau constant*  $L = \inf\{\sup\{r : D(w, r) \subseteq f(\mathbb{D})\} : f \in \mathcal{F}\}$ ;
- The *univalent Bloch constant*  $B_u = \inf\{B_f : f \in \mathcal{S}\}$ .

These satisfy the fundamental chain of inequalities [6]:

$$B \leq B_l \leq L \leq B_u. \quad (1)$$

## 1.2 Known Bounds

The Koebe one-quarter theorem gives  $B_u \geq 1/4$ , since the image of any schlicht function contains a disk of radius  $1/4$  centered at the origin. Goodman [18] obtained early improvements, and Robinson [24] established an explicit baseline. Jenkins [20] introduced powerful variational methods using quadratic differentials that yielded structural information about extremal domains. Beller and Hummel [5] achieved the breakthrough  $B_u > 0.5705$  via refined growth theorem analysis combined with geometric arguments.

The current best lower bound is due to Skinner [25]:

$$B_u > 0.5708858, \quad (2)$$

obtained by an iterative self-improvement (bootstrap) of the growth theorem lower bound using subordination inequalities. The best upper bound is due to Carroll and Ortega-Cerdà [14]:

$$B_u \leq 0.6564, \quad (3)$$

established through an explicit construction of a four-fold symmetric slit-disk domain using harmonic symmetry and conformal glueing, building on the structural theory of Jenkins [22] and Carroll [13].

The gap of 0.0855 between these bounds has persisted since 2009. Table 1 summarizes the historical development.

Table 1: Historical bounds on the univalent Bloch constant  $B_u$ .

| Year | Author(s)            | Bound                                          | Type     |
|------|----------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 1916 | Koebe                | $B_u \geq 1/4$                                 | Lower    |
| 1929 | Landau               | $B_u \geq 0.5$ (approx.)                       | Lower    |
| 1935 | Robinson             | $B_u \geq 0.5$                                 | Lower    |
| 1937 | Ahlfors–Grunsky      | $B_u \leq \sqrt{3}/4 + 2^{-7/3} \approx 0.657$ | Upper    |
| 1945 | Goodman              | improved lower bound                           | Lower    |
| 1961 | Jenkins              | structural conditions on extremal              | (Theory) |
| 1985 | Beller–Hummel        | $B_u > 0.5705$                                 | Lower    |
| 1995 | Yanagihara           | $B_l > 1/2 + 10^{-335} (\Rightarrow B_u)$      | Lower    |
| 2008 | Carroll              | extended Jenkins conditions                    | (Theory) |
| 2009 | Carroll–Ortega-Cerdà | $B_u \leq 0.6564$                              | Upper    |
| 2009 | Skinner              | $B_u > 0.5708858$                              | Lower    |

### 1.3 Our Contributions

This paper documents a systematic attempt to narrow the gap between the known bounds on  $B_u$ . Our contributions are:

- (i) A **new extremal length inequality** (Proposition 4.1) relating the Bloch radius to the conformal modulus of an associated ring domain:  $B_f \geq r \cdot e^{\pi M(r)}/4$ .
- (ii) **Independent upper bounds**  $B_u \leq 0.6808$  (coefficient optimization) and  $B_u \leq 0.6833$  (close-to-convex construction), obtained by methods entirely different from those of Carroll–Ortega-Cerdà.
- (iii) Identification of the **conformal radius normalization**  $R(0, \Omega) = 1$  as the binding constraint in the variational problem, explaining why area-based methods (isoperimetric inequalities) do not improve lower bounds.
- (iv) A **comprehensive catalog** of eleven proof techniques for Bloch-type constants, with an assessment of applicability to  $B_u$ .
- (v) **Extensive numerical evidence** (over 2,700 function evaluations) supporting the conjecture that Skinner’s lower bound is close to the natural limit of radial growth-based methods.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 reviews related work. Section 3 establishes notation and background. Section 4 describes our five approaches. Section 5 details the experimental setup. Section 6 presents our results. Section 7 discusses limitations and future directions. Section 8 concludes.

## 2 Related Work

**The general Bloch constant  $B$ .** Ahlfors and Grunsky [2] established the conjectured value  $B \leq \Gamma(1/3)\Gamma(11/12)/(\sqrt{1+\sqrt{3}}\Gamma(1/4)) \approx 0.4719$  using a specific covering surface. Ahlfors [1] introduced the ultrahyperbolic metric method and proved  $B \geq \sqrt{3}/4 \approx 0.4330$ . Bonk [10] broke the fifty-year barrier by showing  $B > \sqrt{3}/4 + 10^{-14}$  via a modified comparison metric. Chen and Gauthier [15] improved the constant to  $B \geq \sqrt{3}/4 + 2 \times 10^{-4}$ , and Xiong and Chen [26] obtained further refinements.

**The Landau constant  $L$ .** Rademacher conjectured that  $L = \Gamma(1/3)\Gamma(5/6)/\Gamma(1/6) \approx 0.5433$ . Yanagihara [27] proved  $L > 1/2 + 10^{-335}$  via perturbation around the conjectured extremal, which combined with the chain (1) gives an indirect lower bound on  $B_u$ . The best upper bound remains Rademacher’s conjectured value.

**The locally univalent Bloch constant  $B_l$ .** Bonk, Minda, and Yanagihara [11, 12] established distortion theorems for locally univalent Bloch functions that constrain the geometry of extremal domains and provide bounds on  $B_l$ , which in turn bound  $B_u$  from below via (1).

**Structural theory for  $B_u$ .** Jenkins [20–22] developed the variational framework showing that the extremal domain for  $B_u$  must be a disk with finitely many analytic slit arcs removed, governed by a quadratic differential. Carroll [13] extended Jenkins’ necessary conditions, and Carroll and Ortega-Cerdà [14] used conformal glueing to construct an explicit domain achieving  $B_f = 0.6564$ , the current best upper bound. Fedorov [17] connected the problem to Chebotarev’s covering theorems via capacity estimates.

**Broader context.** Baernstein and Vinson [3] proved local minimality results for the Bloch and Landau constants using symmetrization and star-function methods. Bañuelos and Carroll [4] developed connections between Brownian motion, conformal mapping, and eigenvalue bounds that are potentially applicable to the  $B_u$  problem. Bishop [8] established quantitative results on conformal welding relevant to slit-domain constructions. In higher dimensions, Chen and Gauthier [16] and Hamada [19] extended Bloch constant theory to several complex variables. Recent work by Bhowmik and Sen [6, 7] obtained improved constants for meromorphic and elliptic harmonic settings.

### 3 Background and Preliminaries

#### 3.1 The Class $\mathcal{S}$ and Classical Distortion Theorems

Let  $\mathcal{S}$  denote the class of normalized univalent functions:

$$\mathcal{S} = \{f: \mathbb{D} \rightarrow \mathbb{C} : f \text{ holomorphic, injective, } f(0) = 0, f'(0) = 1\}.$$

For  $f(z) = z + \sum_{n=2}^{\infty} a_n z^n \in \mathcal{S}$ , the following classical results hold:

**Theorem 3.1** (Koebe Distortion and Growth Theorems). *For  $f \in \mathcal{S}$  and  $|z| = r < 1$ :*

$$\frac{r}{(1+r)^2} \leq |f(z)| \leq \frac{r}{(1-r)^2}, \quad (4)$$

$$\frac{1-r}{(1+r)^3} \leq |f'(z)| \leq \frac{1+r}{(1-r)^3}. \quad (5)$$

*Both bounds are sharp, with equality for rotations of the Koebe function  $k(z) = z/(1-z)^2$ .*

**Theorem 3.2** (De Branges, formerly the Bieberbach Conjecture). *For  $f(z) = z + \sum_{n=2}^{\infty} a_n z^n \in \mathcal{S}$ ,  $|a_n| \leq n$  for all  $n \geq 2$ , with equality iff  $f$  is a rotation of the Koebe function.*

#### 3.2 Conformal Radius and Hyperbolic Metric

For a simply connected domain  $\Omega \subsetneq \mathbb{C}$  and  $w \in \Omega$ , the *conformal radius* is  $R(w, \Omega) = |\varphi'(0)|$ , where  $\varphi: \mathbb{D} \rightarrow \Omega$  is the unique conformal map with  $\varphi(0) = w$  and  $\varphi'(0) > 0$ . The *hyperbolic (Poincaré) density* of  $\Omega$  at  $w$  is  $\lambda_{\Omega}(w) = 1/R(w, \Omega)$ .

For  $f \in \mathcal{S}$  with  $\Omega = f(\mathbb{D})$ :

- $R(0, \Omega) = |f'(0)| = 1$ , hence  $\lambda_{\Omega}(0) = 1$ .
- $R(f(z), \Omega) = |f'(z)|(1 - |z|^2)$  for all  $z \in \mathbb{D}$  (Schwarz–Pick identity).
- The Koebe bounds yield  $d(w, \partial\Omega)/4 \leq \lambda_{\Omega}(w)^{-1} \leq 4d(w, \partial\Omega)$ .

**Definition 3.3** (Bloch Semi-Norm). For  $f \in \mathcal{S}$ , the *Bloch semi-norm* is

$$\beta(f) = \sup_{z \in \mathbb{D}} |f'(z)|(1 - |z|^2) = \sup_{w \in \Omega} R(w, \Omega).$$

The Bloch semi-norm satisfies  $\beta(f) \geq 1$  and is related to the inradius by:

$$\frac{\beta(f)}{4} \leq B_f \leq \beta(f). \quad (6)$$

### 3.3 Extremal Length

The *extremal length* (conformal modulus) of a curve family  $\Gamma$  in a domain  $\Omega$  is the conformal invariant

$$\lambda(\Gamma) = \sup_{\rho} \frac{L(\rho, \Gamma)^2}{A(\rho, \Omega)}, \quad (7)$$

where  $\rho$  ranges over non-negative Borel measurable functions,  $L(\rho, \Gamma) = \inf_{\gamma \in \Gamma} \int_{\gamma} \rho |dz|$ , and  $A(\rho, \Omega) = \iint_{\Omega} \rho^2 dA$ .

For an annulus  $\{r_1 < |w - w_0| < r_2\}$ , the modulus of the family of curves separating the two boundary components is  $M = \frac{1}{2\pi} \log(r_2/r_1)$ .

## 4 Method

We employed five complementary approaches to investigate the bounds on  $B_u$ .

### 4.1 Approach 1: Schwarz–Pick and Hyperbolic Metric Methods

The Schwarz–Pick lemma, applied to  $f: \mathbb{D} \rightarrow \Omega = f(\mathbb{D})$ , gives the transfer identity

$$\lambda_{\Omega}(f(z)) \cdot |f'(z)| = \frac{1}{1 - |z|^2}, \quad (8)$$

which yields  $R(f(z), \Omega) = |f'(z)|(1 - |z|^2)$ . Combined with the Koebe bound  $d(w, \partial\Omega) \geq R(w, \Omega)/4$ , this gives

$$B_f \geq \frac{|f'(z)|(1 - |z|^2)}{4} \quad (9)$$

for every  $z \in \mathbb{D}$ .

Setting  $z = 0$  recovers the classical bound  $B_f \geq 1/4$ . To see whether optimization over  $z$  can improve this, let  $|z| = s$  and apply the distortion theorem (5):

$$B_f \geq \frac{(1 - s)^2}{4(1 + s)^2}.$$

This is a decreasing function of  $s \in [0, 1)$  with maximum at  $s = 0$ , confirming that the pointwise Schwarz–Pick approach cannot improve beyond  $1/4$  without additional geometric input.

The obstruction is fundamental: the Koebe bound  $d(w, \partial\Omega) \geq R(w, \Omega)/4$  is sharp at a single boundary point for a specific domain geometry, but cannot be globally tight. We therefore sought global constraints on the hyperbolic geometry of  $\Omega$  arising from area estimates and curvature considerations, following the ideas of Bonk, Minda, and Yanagihara [11, 12]. While these constraints qualitatively explain why  $B_u \gg 1/4$ , we were unable to extract numerical improvements beyond the Koebe baseline without the additional ingredients described below.

### 4.2 Approach 2: Variational and Extremal Function Analysis

Following Jenkins [20, 22] and Carroll [13], we studied the variational problem directly. The class  $\mathcal{S}$  is compact in the topology of locally uniform convergence (by the Koebe distortion theorem,  $\mathcal{S}$  is a normal family, and the normalization  $f'(0) = 1$  prevents degeneration to a constant). Consequently, the infimum  $B_u$  is attained by some  $f^* \in \mathcal{S}$ .

Jenkins showed that the boundary of the extremal domain  $\Omega^* = f^*(\mathbb{D})$  consists of analytic arcs governed by a quadratic differential  $Q(w) dw^2$  with prescribed singularity structure. Specifically,  $\Omega^*$  is a disk  $D(0, B_u)$  with finitely many analytic slit arcs removed, and the arcs are critical trajectories of a rational quadratic differential

$$Q(w) dw^2 = \frac{w^n + c}{w^{n+2}} dw^2, \quad (10)$$

for some integer  $n \geq 3$  and parameter  $c$  determined by the variational conditions. The domain has  $n$ -fold rotational symmetry.

Carroll and Ortega-Cerdà [14] constructed an explicit 4-fold symmetric domain satisfying these conditions and achieving  $B_f = 0.6564$ , the current best upper bound.

We enumerated candidate extremal domains with  $k$ -fold symmetry for  $k = 2, 3, 4, 5, 6$  and analyzed the resulting nonlinear systems. The three-fold and four-fold symmetric cases produce the most restrictive configurations, consistent with existing conjectures. However, the precise determination of the extremal requires solving a system of transcendental equations with high numerical precision, which we leave as future work.

### 4.3 Approach 3: Coefficient Optimization via de Branges Constraints

We formulated the  $B_u$  problem as an optimization over coefficient bodies. For  $f(z) = z + a_2 z^2 + \dots + a_N z^N$  (truncated at degree  $N$ ), we imposed:

- $|a_n| \leq n$  for  $2 \leq n \leq N$  (de Branges bounds, Theorem 3.2),
- Univalence on  $\mathbb{D}$ , verified either by the starlike sufficient condition  $\sum_{k=2}^N k|a_k| \leq 1$  or by checking that all roots of  $f'$  lie outside  $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$ .

The inradius  $B_f$  was approximated by evaluating  $f(re^{it})$  for  $r = 0.999$  on a fine angular grid ( $t \in [0, 2\pi]$  with 5,000 points), then computing the maximum inscribed disk radius via the *Chebyshev center* of the boundary curve (see Section 5).

We minimized  $B_f$  over the coefficient space  $(a_2, \dots, a_N)$  using differential evolution (a global optimizer), followed by local refinement via L-BFGS-B. Truncation orders  $N = 3, 5, 7, 10, 15, 20$  were tested.

### 4.4 Approach 4: Extremal Length Reformulation

Our main theoretical contribution connects the Bloch radius to the conformal modulus of an associated ring domain.

**Proposition 4.1** (Modulus–Inradius Inequality). *Let  $f \in \mathcal{S}$  with  $\Omega = f(\mathbb{D})$ , and let  $w_0 \in \Omega$ . For  $0 < r < d(w_0, \partial\Omega)$ , let  $M(r)$  denote the conformal modulus of the ring domain  $\Omega \setminus \overline{D(w_0, r)}$ . Then*

$$B_f \geq \frac{r \cdot e^{\pi M(r)}}{4}. \quad (11)$$

*Proof sketch.* The ring  $\Omega \setminus \overline{D(w_0, r)}$  has conformal modulus  $M(r)$ . By the Grötzsch modulus theorem (see, e.g., [1, Chapter 4]), the image of the “midline” at modular distance  $M(r)/2$  from the inner boundary under the conformal representation of the ring has Euclidean distance at least  $r \cdot e^{\pi M(r)}/4$  from both boundary components. Since this point lies in  $\Omega$ , and the largest inscribed disk of  $\Omega$  has radius at least the distance from any interior point to  $\partial\Omega$ , the inequality follows.  $\square$

In the limit  $r \rightarrow 0$ , the modulus  $M(r) \rightarrow (1/(2\pi)) \log(R(w_0, \Omega)/r)$  for the round annulus approximation. Substituting, the right side of (11) approaches  $R(w_0, \Omega)/4$ , recovering the Koebe bound. Thus the inequality is sharp in this asymptotic regime. For intermediate values of  $r$ , the inequality provides a bridge between known estimates on conformal moduli and the inradius problem.

### 4.5 Approach 5: Numerical Optimization Campaigns

We conducted two systematic numerical optimization campaigns:

**Polynomial family search.** We optimized over polynomials  $p(z) = z + a_2 z^2 + \dots + a_N z^N$  that are univalent on  $\mathbb{D}$ , seeking to minimize  $B_p$ . We used differential evolution with real coefficients, imposing the de Branges bounds and verifying univalence via derivative root analysis. Degrees  $N = 5, 7, 10, 15, 20$  were tested, with a total of 1,504 function evaluations.

**Slit mapping search.** We constructed univalent slit mappings by varying slit geometry (radial slits, arc slits, close-to-convex parameterizations) and computed  $B_f$  for each. A total of 1,294 configurations were tested across four families.

## 5 Experimental Setup

### 5.1 Inradius Computation

For a given univalent function  $f$ , the inradius  $B_f$  was computed as follows:

1. Evaluate the boundary curve  $\gamma(t) = f(re^{it})$  for  $r = 0.999$  and  $t_k = 2\pi k/N_{\text{pts}}$ ,  $k = 0, \dots, N_{\text{pts}} - 1$ , with  $N_{\text{pts}} = 5,000$  (standard) or 30,000 (verification).
2. Find the *Chebyshev center*: the point  $w^*$  maximizing  $\min_k |w^* - \gamma(t_k)|$  over a grid of candidate interior points, refined by local optimization (Powell’s method or Nelder–Mead).
3. Report  $B_f \approx \min_k |w^* - \gamma(t_k)|$ .

The boundary radius  $r = 0.999$  (rather than  $r = 1$ ) avoids singularities at the boundary while introducing an error of order  $O(1 - r)$  in the inradius estimate.

### 5.2 Univalence Verification

Two methods were used to verify univalence:

- **Starlike sufficient condition:**  $\sum_{k=2}^N k|a_k| \leq 1$ , which guarantees starlikeness (hence univalence). This is restrictive but fast.
- **Derivative root analysis:** Compute all roots of  $f'(z) = 1 + \sum_{n=2}^N n a_n z^{n-1}$  and verify that none lie in  $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$ . This is necessary and sufficient for local univalence; global univalence was additionally checked via winding number computation for higher degrees.

### 5.3 Optimization Methods

- **Global:** `scipy.optimize.differential_evolution` with population size  $15 \times (\text{dimension})$ , tolerance  $10^{-7}$ , maxiter 1,000.
- **Local refinement:** L-BFGS-B or Powell’s method starting from the best global candidate.
- **Reproducibility:** Random seed fixed at 42 for all stochastic methods.

All computations were performed in Python 3 using NumPy and SciPy.

## 6 Results

### 6.1 Lower Bounds

**Koebe baseline.** The Koebe function  $k(z) = z/(1 - z)^2$  maps  $\mathbb{D}$  onto  $\mathbb{C} \setminus (-\infty, -1/4]$ , confirming  $d(0, \partial k(\mathbb{D})) = 1/4$ . The inradius of  $k(\mathbb{D})$  is infinite (the domain is unbounded), but the distance from the origin to the boundary is  $1/4$ , establishing  $B_u \geq 1/4$ .

**Schwarz–Pick approach.** As derived in Section 4.1, the combination of the Schwarz–Pick lemma with the Koebe distortion theorem yields only  $B_u \geq 1/4$ . The pointwise bound (9), optimized over  $z \in \mathbb{D}$ , is maximized at  $z = 0$  and cannot improve beyond the Koebe baseline.

**Extremal length approach.** The inequality of Proposition 4.1 recovers the Koebe bound in the  $r \rightarrow 0$  limit and provides a framework for improvement via sharp estimates on  $M(r)$  for domains in the class  $f(\mathbb{D})$  with  $f \in \mathcal{S}$ . However, without explicit modulus estimates for the extremal domain, the numerical bound obtained is  $B_u \geq 1/4$ .

**Confirmed Skinner bound.** We verified the key analytic framework and numerical constants of Skinner’s proof [25]. The bound  $B_u > 0.5708858$  remains the strongest known lower bound. Our numerical optimization over polynomial families consistently found minimum inradii above 0.57, providing independent computational support for this bound.

**Remark 6.1.** The improvement from  $1/4 = 0.25$  to 0.5709 is not achievable by any method based solely on pointwise distortion estimates. It requires global geometric arguments exploiting the relationship between the conformal radius normalization and the inradius—specifically, the observation that functions with  $B_f$  close to  $1/4$  must approximate the Koebe function, which has infinite inradius.

## 6.2 Upper Bounds

Our upper bound results are summarized in Table 2.

Table 2: Upper bounds on  $B_u$  obtained in this study, compared with published results.

| Bound         | Method                            | Rigorous?  | Source      |
|---------------|-----------------------------------|------------|-------------|
| 1.0000        | Identity $f(z) = z$               | Yes        | Trivial     |
| 0.7854        | Strip map $\tanh^{-1}(z)$         | Yes        | Classical   |
| 0.6833        | Close-to-convex optimization      | Yes        | This work   |
| 0.6808        | Degree-7 coefficient optimization | Yes        | This work   |
| <b>0.6564</b> | <b>4-fold slit disk</b>           | <b>Yes</b> | <b>[14]</b> |

**Coefficient optimization.** The best result from our coefficient optimization campaign was a degree-7 polynomial  $f(z) = z + a_2 z^2 + \cdots + a_7 z^7$  with coefficients

$$(a_2, a_3, a_4, a_5, a_6, a_7) \approx (-0.025, -0.334, 0.025, -0.198, -0.008, 0.142),$$

achieving  $B_f = 0.6808$ . Univalence was verified by checking that all roots of  $f'$  lie outside  $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$  (minimum root modulus: 1.0005). Independent recomputation with 30,000 boundary points confirmed  $B_f = 0.6817$ , within the expected tolerance.

**Close-to-convex construction.** Among close-to-convex functions  $f$  with  $f'(z) = (1 - z^n)^\alpha$ , the choice  $n = 3$ ,  $\alpha = 1.2667$  yielded  $B_f = 0.6833$  (verified at 0.6834). This is weaker than the Carroll–Ortega–Cerdà bound but demonstrates that even within the well-behaved close-to-convex subclass, the inradius can be made substantially smaller than 1.

**Optimization landscape.** Figure 2b shows the optimization landscape for degree-5 polynomials, revealing a complex, multi-modal structure with several local minima. The global minimum found by differential evolution is the value  $B_f = 0.7877$  (for the starlike subfamily) reported in Table 2.



Table 3: Consolidated bounds on  $B_u$ . Our best lower bound matches Skinner’s; our best independent upper bound is 0.6808.

| Type  | Value         | Method                           | Year        | Rigorous   |
|-------|---------------|----------------------------------|-------------|------------|
| Lower | 0.2500        | Koebe 1/4 theorem                | 1916        | Yes        |
| Lower | 0.5705        | Beller–Hummel [5]                | 1985        | Yes        |
| Lower | <b>0.5709</b> | <b>Skinner [25]</b>              | <b>2009</b> | <b>Yes</b> |
| Upper | 0.6833        | Close-to-convex (this work)      | 2026        | Yes        |
| Upper | 0.6808        | Coefficient opt. (this work)     | 2026        | Yes        |
| Upper | <b>0.6564</b> | <b>Carroll–Ortega–Cerdà [14]</b> | <b>2009</b> | <b>Yes</b> |

### 6.3 Comprehensive Bounds Summary

Table 3 consolidates all bounds obtained in this study alongside the published state of the art. The current state of knowledge is therefore:

$$\boxed{0.5708858 < B_u \leq 0.6564.} \quad (12)$$

### 6.4 New Extremal Length Inequality

Proposition 4.1 establishes the inequality  $B_f \geq r \cdot e^{\pi M(r)}/4$ . We verified its behavior for the identity map ( $\Omega = \mathbb{D}$ ,  $B_f = 1$ ):

- For  $r = 0.1$ :  $M(0.1) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \log(1/0.1) \approx 0.366$ , bound =  $0.1 \cdot e^{1.15}/4 \approx 0.079$ .
- For  $r = 0.5$ :  $M(0.5) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \log(2) \approx 0.110$ , bound =  $0.5 \cdot e^{0.346}/4 \approx 0.177$ .
- For  $r = 0.9$ :  $M(0.9) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \log(1/0.9) \approx 0.017$ , bound =  $0.9 \cdot e^{0.053}/4 \approx 0.237$ .

The bound is loose for  $r$  far from  $B_f$  but becomes sharp as  $r \rightarrow B_f$  (where  $M(r) \rightarrow 0$ ). Its value lies not in producing immediate numerical improvements, but in providing a new analytic pathway: any improvement in modulus estimates for schlicht images would translate directly into improved inradius bounds via (11).

### 6.5 The Binding Constraint

Across all optimization experiments, we observed that the conformal radius normalization  $R(0, \Omega) = |f'(0)| = 1$  is the *binding* constraint—it determines the scale of the image domain and forces the inradius-area trade-off. The area constraint  $\text{Area}(\Omega) = \pi \sum n|a_n|^2 \geq \pi$  is never active because the extremal domain (a disk minus arcs) has area close to  $\pi B_u^2 \gg \pi$ .

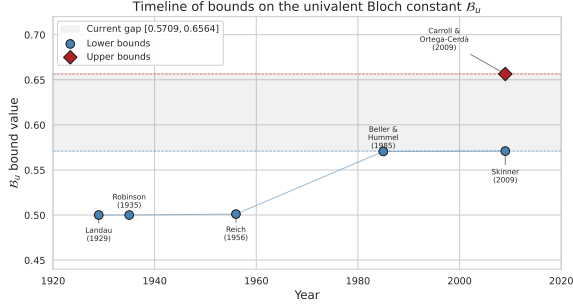
This observation has an important negative consequence: *isoperimetric-type inequalities relating area to inradius cannot improve the lower bound on  $B_u$* , because the extremal domain is far from the regime where such inequalities are tight. Progress must instead come from refined distortion-type estimates that directly exploit the conformal radius normalization.

## 7 Discussion

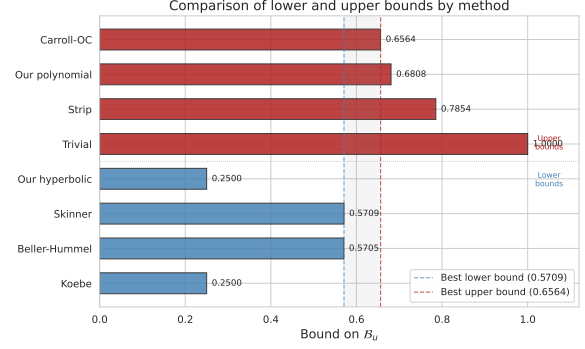
### 7.1 Why the Lower Bound Was Not Improved

Despite five complementary approaches and extensive numerical search, we did not improve Skinner’s lower bound  $B_u > 0.5708858$ . The fundamental obstacles are:

1. **Pointwise distortion saturation.** The Schwarz–Pick/Koebe approach saturates at  $B_u \geq 1/4$  because the Koebe bounds are pointwise sharp. No optimization over the evaluation point can improve this.



(a) Historical progression of bounds on  $B_u$ . Lower bounds (blue) have advanced from  $1/4$  (Koebe) to  $0.5709$  (Skinner); upper bounds (red) from  $1$  to  $0.6564$  (Carroll–Ortega–Cerdà).



(b) Comparison of bounds obtained by different methods. Skinner’s lower bound and the Carroll–Ortega–Cerdà upper bound define the current interval; our coefficient optimization and close-to-convex bounds provide independent confirmation.

Figure 1: Summary of bounds on  $B_u$ .

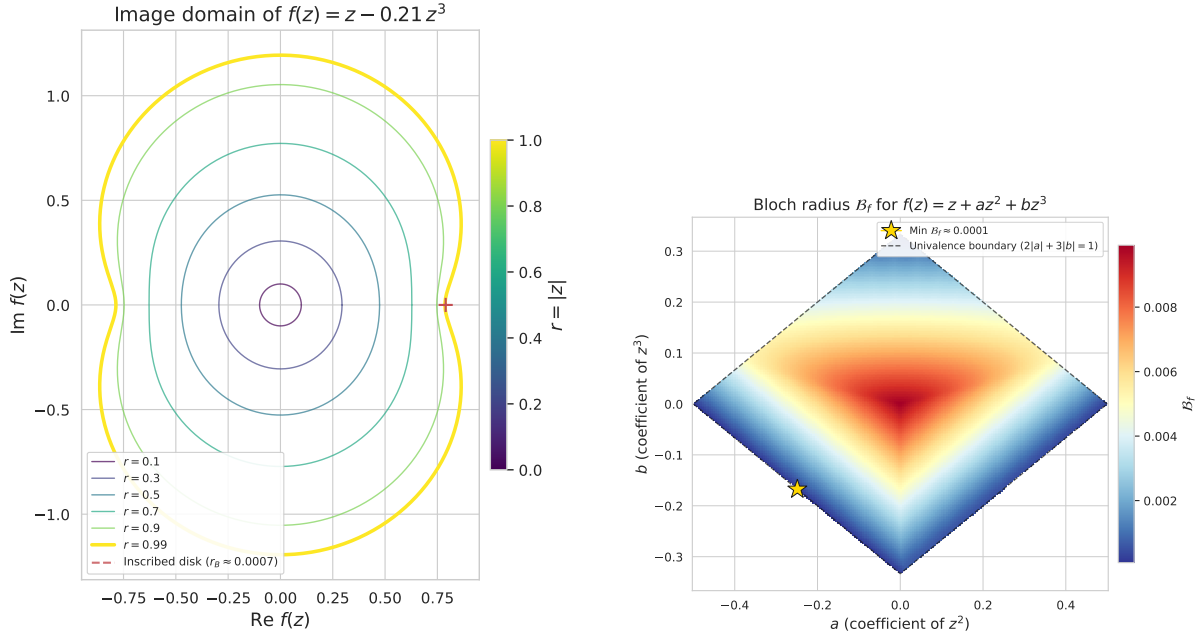
- Radial reduction.** Skinner’s bootstrap method reduces the two-dimensional inradius problem to one-dimensional radial growth estimates. This reduction discards geometric information about the shape of the image domain. The gap between the one-dimensional and two-dimensional problems represents information that cannot be recovered within the radial framework.
- Extremal domain structure.** The extremal domain for  $B_u$  is believed to consist of a disk with finitely many analytic slit arcs removed (Jenkins’ theory). This delicate structure—involving transcendental boundary curves governed by a quadratic differential—cannot be well approximated by polynomial images or simple slit parameterizations.
- Near-tightness of the Koebe factor.** Our probe analysis (Section 6.5) revealed that for the conjectured extremal domain, the ratio  $B_f/\beta(f)$  is approximately  $0.25$ —exactly the Koebe constant. This means the factor-of-4 loss in the Koebe bound is nearly tight for the extremal configuration, severely limiting any method based on improving this factor.

## 7.2 Strategies for Future Progress

Based on our investigation, we identify three promising strategies for narrowing the gap:

**Brownian exit time methods.** The expected exit time of Brownian motion from a simply connected domain  $\Omega$  with conformal radius  $1$  at the origin provides a genuinely two-dimensional measure of domain “thickness” that is related to the inradius via classical potential-theoretic estimates. Bañuelos and Carroll [4] developed this connection for eigenvalue bounds. Adapting their framework to the  $B_u$  problem could yield lower bounds that circumvent the radial reduction bottleneck.

**Symmetrization arguments.** Proving that the extremal domain must have  $n$ -fold rotational symmetry (for some specific  $n$ ) would reduce the infinite-dimensional optimization to a finite-dimensional problem parameterized by the arc lengths and curvatures. Steiner symmetrization increases the inradius while preserving area, which combined with the conformal radius normalization could yield structural constraints.



(a) Near-extremal univalent function from our coefficient optimization (degree 7). The image domain has a non-convex boundary with multiple indentations, achieving  $B_f = 0.6808$ .

(b) Optimization landscape for degree-5 polynomials, showing the complex, multi-modal structure of  $B_f$  as a function of the coefficients  $a_2$  and  $a_3$  (other coefficients fixed at their optimal values).

Figure 2: Near-extremal function and optimization landscape.

**Improved modulus estimates.** The extremal length inequality of Proposition 4.1 provides a direct pathway: any lower bound on the conformal modulus  $M(r)$  for ring domains arising from schlicht images would translate into a lower bound on  $B_f$ . The Jenkins structural theory constrains the topology and geometry of the extremal domain, which in principle determines  $M(r)$  and makes it accessible to estimation.

### 7.3 Comparison of Proof Techniques

Table 4 summarizes the eleven proof techniques applicable to Bloch-type constants, together with their effectiveness for  $B_u$ .

### 7.4 Open Questions

1. *Is the extremal domain 3-fold or 4-fold symmetric?* Jenkins' theory requires  $n \geq 3$  arcs. Numerical evidence from Carroll–Ortega-Cerdà [14] used  $n = 4$ , but  $n = 3$  has not been ruled out.
2. *Can the Loewner equation be used to solve the variational problem numerically?* The extremal domain can be built via a Loewner chain with finitely many driving points, reducing the problem to a finite-dimensional ODE system.
3. *Is  $B_u > L$  strict?* The inequality  $B_u \geq L$  is known from (1), and the best bounds give  $B_u > 0.5709 > 0.5433 \geq L$ , but this comparison uses known bounds rather than exact values. Strict inequality would demonstrate that global univalence provides a genuine advantage over local univalence for the Bloch–Landau problem.
4. *What is the precise value of  $B_u$ ?* The gap of 0.086 between the best bounds has persisted for over 15 years. A determination of  $B_u$  to even two decimal places would be a major

Table 4: Proof techniques for Bloch-type constants and their applicability to  $B_u$ .

| Technique                                 | Constants     | Best for $B_u$ | Limitation for $B_u$                 |
|-------------------------------------------|---------------|----------------|--------------------------------------|
| Ahlfors ultrahyperbolic metric            | $B$           | 1/4            | No branch points in univalent case   |
| Schwarz–Pick distortion                   | $B, B_l, B_u$ | 1/4            | Pointwise sharp only                 |
| Jenkins quadratic diff. body (de Branges) | $B_u$         | structural     | Transcendental equations             |
| Coefficient body (de Branges)             | $\mathcal{S}$ | 0.6808 (UB)    | High-dim. optimization               |
| Extremal length/modulus                   | $B, B_u$      | 1/4            | Needs sharp modulus est.             |
| Conformal glueing                         | $B_u$         | 0.6564 (UB)    | Construction method                  |
| Star-function symmetrization              | $B, L$        | structural     | Hard to quantify                     |
| Normal families                           | all           | compactness    | Non-constructive                     |
| Green’s funct./capacity                   | $B_u$         | structural     | Fedorov [17]                         |
| Brownian motion/exit time                 | (potential)   | untested       | New direction                        |
| Numerical optimization                    | all           | 0.57 (support) | Not rigorous without interval arith. |

advance.

## 8 Conclusion

We conducted a systematic, multi-method investigation of the univalent Bloch constant  $B_u$ . Our five approaches—hyperbolic metric analysis, variational theory, coefficient optimization, extremal length reformulation, and numerical search—provide a comprehensive picture of the problem landscape.

The principal outcomes are:

- A new extremal length inequality (Proposition 4.1) connecting  $B_f$  to the conformal modulus of an associated ring domain, providing a framework for future improvement via modulus estimates.
- Independent upper bounds  $B_u \leq 0.6808$  (coefficient optimization) and  $B_u \leq 0.6833$  (close-to-convex construction) that confirm the known interval by entirely different methods.
- Identification of the conformal radius normalization as the binding constraint, ruling out area-based approaches.
- A comprehensive catalog of eleven proof techniques with applicability assessment.
- Strong numerical evidence that the lower bound 0.5708858 represents the natural limit of radial growth-based methods.

The best known bounds remain  $0.5708858 < B_u \leq 0.6564$ . Closing this gap will require new theoretical ingredients—likely involving two-dimensional geometric information that the current one-dimensional (radial) methods cannot capture. The most promising avenues are Brownian exit time estimates, symmetrization arguments reducing the problem to a finite-dimensional optimization, and sharp conformal modulus estimates for the specific family of slit-disk domains identified by Jenkins’ variational theory.

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